

The Coin and the Witch — Sections VIII–IX: The bridge literature and where it's still missing

The Coin and the Witch: A Federician Iconography of Female Allegory

VIII. Who has tried to bridge Warner and Federici

The four case studies of Sections IV–VII are, so far as this essay could determine, synthetic — no published work stages the argument that Marianne, Britannia, Justitia, and Columbia are one template with four variations. But the essay is not proposing to build the bridge on empty ground. A scattered but real body of scholarship has been working the space between Warner's iconographic tradition and Federici's political economy, mostly in one direction: from Federici into visual studies, much less from visual studies back into political economy. The current has enough coherence to name, and enough limits to name too. This section catalogues the closest predecessors; Section IX says what they leave undone.

Gen Doy, *Seeing and Consciousness: Women, Class and Representation* (1995). Doy is the closest programmatic predecessor for a Marxist-feminist iconography of women, and she predates Federici's mainstream uptake. Her project is stated directly: the book "challenges the widespread belief that Marxism has nothing valuable to contribute to women's studies" through "its provocative examination of feminist and Marxist approaches to women's art and female representations"[1]. The load-bearing claim: "from the French Revolution through to the present, gender *and* class have shaped visual imagery," and Marxist theory can be used "to question some of the premises of feminist art histories and to provide a more accurate understanding of the meaning(s) of visual imagery"[1]. Her chapter list itself sketches a periodisation the present essay could almost import wholesale: "Marxist theory, feminism(s) and women's history women and the bourgeois revolution of 1789 — artists, mothers and markers of (art) history gender and class in early modernist painting — a reassessment women, class and photography — the Paris commune of 1871 Russia and the Soviet Union ca.1880–ca.1940 — 'patriarchal' culture or 'totalitarian androgeny'? women and Nazi art — Nazi women and art the postmodern, gender and race"[2]. Doy's revolutionary-France chapter is, effectively, the political-economic exterior of Section IV's Marianne — the class analysis of the female sign that consolidates in 1789–1793. What Doy does not have, because *Caliban and the Witch* had not yet been written in her form, is Federici's specific mechanism: the witch hunt and the disciplined reproductive body as the constitutive violence of primitive accumulation. Doy has the class analysis without the reproductive-labour argument. The two arguments are compatible; nobody has combined them on the object of civic female allegory.

Žana Kozomora, "To Conjure Her" (2022). Kozomora is the most explicit single-essay bridge this essay's search located. She reads contemporary ex-Yugoslav artists — Selma Selman and Šejla Kamerić — "through the figure of the Slavic 'witch' via feminist scholar Silvia Federici"[3]. What makes the essay a genuine bridge, rather than another application of Federici to contemporary art, is that Kozomora holds both frames at once. She acknowledges the periodisation problem head-on: "the South Slavic Balkans didn't experience the particular witch-hunts that Federici's reading of history charts," but Federici's theory "helps consider contemporary conditions that reflect neocolonialism, particularly the outbreak of the 1990s Yugoslav war with the official destruction of socialism and transition to fully fleshed capitalism" — and if that violent transition "casts women as witches, then the degree of power they held was reaffirmed as a threat to the construction of the new capitalist nation-state"[3]. She then names the Warnerian half of the object explicitly: during the war, women were "classed as 'national traitors' by an increasingly dominant, chauvinistic discourse that understood women as metaphoric markers of the national body, a symbolic battlefield in which women's bodies..." carry the mark of the nation[3]. That formulation — the woman as *metaphoric marker of the national body, a symbolic battlefield* — is exactly the Warnerian object (the female form as vessel for civic universals) held inside a Federician frame (primitive accumulation, capitalist transition, criminalisation of female autonomy).

Kozomora does what Warner's tradition rarely does — names the political economy under the symbol — and what Federici rarely does — works through specific images and specific artists. What the essay is not is what this essay is trying to be: it operates on contemporary art rather than on the historical civic allegories that consolidated the template.

The "witching of art history" current — Deepwell, Naessens, Kokkinen, Turley-Sonne. A loose but recognisable body of work from the late 2010s onward uses Federici as theoretical scaffolding for reading the witch in contemporary art. Deepwell's 2015 ICA conference *Misogyny: Witches and Wicked Bodies* asked directly whether historical witch imagery is "'woman-hating' or misogynist" and what feminist artists do with it — the panel included Alexandra Kokoli, Lynne Segal, and Deepwell herself[4]. Naessens's study of contemporary practice traces a broad genealogy: many contemporary artists "call upon the iconography of witchcraft, rewriting its past stories, exploring current ones, or actualizing practices and gestures (Camille Ducellier, Tatiana Karl Pez, Myriam Mihindou)"; "beyond folklore and esotericism, the witch is for these artists a figure of female emancipation with powerful subversive potential"; "since the creation of the W.I.T.C.H. and the birth of anti-nuclear movements in the United States in the 1970s, women have emerged as producers of rituals capable of generating collective power from different perspectives of struggle (feminist, ecologist, anti-capitalist)"; and this "militant projection is now resurfacing with force, particularly through the first gatherings of Witch Bloc Paris"[5]. Kokkinen frames the whole project as a methodological turn: "witching" functions "as a political term, inviting a reimagining of normative approaches to art history and its intersections with esotericism, occultism and magic," and reflects "how artists have reclaimed the figure of 'the witch' — once stigmatised as evil and perverse — and transformed it into a symbol of empowerment"[6]. Turley-Sonne's *Art & Magic* attempts a long genealogy: "Art Witches have created powerful images that resonate with beauty and activism, from Italian courtrooms in the 1500s to binding spells for the Trump presidency in 2016"; the book "for the first time... connects the genealogy of the image of the witch from historical artists to contemporary artists" and asks how the narrative is "exposed and curated in museums and memorials focused on witchcraft"[7].

The limit of the "witching" current, from the point of view of the argument this essay is trying to build, is worth naming precisely. Federici is cited *for the witch* — for the history that authorises the rehabilitation of the figure — but not for the iconographic argument the essay wants. These writers import her political economy to license their reading of images; they do not reciprocally pressure her theory with what images do. The direction of traffic is one-way. And the object is the witch, not the civic Maiden. What the current shows is that the traffic *between* the two literatures is real, and has produced a decade of interesting work; what it does not show is that anyone has yet run the traffic on Warner's canonical objects.

Jaleh Mansoor, "Militant Landscape" (2021). Mansoor's is a different kind of bridge — not the witch but landscape, not iconography of the female body but of the extractive terrain. She reads Turner's *Rain, Steam, and Speed* (1844) — "the first landscape painting to both articulate the ontological shifts brought about by new modes of extraction and production, but also to suggest concomitant transformation in perception" — against Marx's 1844 *Manuscripts*, and then reads Zachary Formwalt's 2013 *Projective Geometry*, which reads aloud from Chapter 25 of *Capital* ("So-called Primitive Accumulation") over "footage — each shot organized in rigorous single point perspective — of the railroad built by England, France, and Belgium extending from the Ivory Coast to the Cape"[8]. Formwalt also "unearthed documents from archives in those Imperialist nation states and former/present empires casually mentioning the now unruly, now obedient, yet always 'pesky' local African labor that lost life to the enterprise"[8]. Mansoor's essay analyses both works "crossing Modernism, aka the culture wing of Modernity (itself a polite term for the ontological shifts brought about by the capitalist mode of production) through the theoretical matrix of Marx, Luxemburg, Sohn-Rethel, and Courtauld"[8]. The witch is absent, and so is the female civic allegory. But the *move* is the one Warner's tradition would need for the present essay: iconographic analysis whose substrate is primitive accumulation, not transhistorical myth. Mansoor demonstrates that art history can be written this way. She does not do it for Marianne, Britannia, Justitia, or Columbia.

Marina Vishmidt, "Speaking of Bodies and Bodies That Speak" (2017). Vishmidt supplies the theoretical hygiene the argument needs to avoid two adjacent errors. The first is a naïve return to "the body" as a pre-political ground; the second is a culturalist reading of the body as pure signifier. Vishmidt refuses both. She notes that the post-structuralist turn to "'the body' as the central signifier of much poststructuralist and post-foundationalist cultural theory and philosophy" and to "'bodies' as the loci of political agency ('bodies assembling', 'Parliament of Bodies')" tends to produce "the possibility of pseudo-concreteness that often accompanies theoretical projects intolerant of (real) abstraction"[9]. She names the specific ideological cost: "the discourse of the body and of bodies elides the question of how and why bodies are produced, accepting the bio-, if not necro-, political, premises of the current dispensation — one that capitalises on the fragile, isolated and suffering body — and converting them into an ethical victory"[9]. This "tends to exemplify rather than challenge a scenario in which 'the reproduction of capitalism and the reproduction of organisms become indistinguishable'"[9]. The question Vishmidt puts at the centre — "what form of social relation makes such a thing as 'the body' not just legible but a departure point for any political subjectivation?"[9] — is the question this essay's argument has been pressing on the four icons. The female body on the coin, on the courthouse pediment, on the seal, is not a pre-political ground; it is the *result* of a specific social relation (primitive accumulation, in Federici's account), staged as if it were the ground.

Maria Daskalaki (2021), on Federici and self-reproducing movements. Daskalaki's contribution is more sociological than iconographic, but it is worth naming here because it does something the "witching of art history" current does not: it operationalises Federici's witch as an *organising* figure, not just an image to be recuperated. Her essay draws on *Caliban and the Witch* directly to think about "crises, struggles over social reproduction, and feminist activist organizing," and works through concrete cases — "the Parisian pétroleuses (the female supporters of the Paris Commune), the Kurdish Women's Movement in Rojava, the Urban Land committees in Venezuela, and the 21st century witch-hunting in Africa" — to argue that "the struggles over social reproduction are intertwined with resistances that enable women to participate in communities that re-embed them in the spheres of feminist activism"[10]. This matters for the essay's argument in an indirect but real way: it establishes that Federici's framework, applied outside the early-modern European window, retains explanatory purchase. The extension from *Caliban* into the postcolonial and contemporary world is not this essay's invention. It is a live current in the reception literature. Marianne and Britannia and Columbia sit inside that longer arc.

Charles Zika, *The Appearance of Witchcraft: Print and Visual Culture in Sixteenth-Century Europe* (2007). The essay saves Zika for last because his contribution runs the traffic in the other direction — from art history *into* Federici — and does the work of materialising Warner's territory back into Federici's period. Zika's book is a "meticulous study" that "demonstrates how social and religious changes during this period came together with demonological theory, and how the resulting visual culture affected the popular perception of witchcraft in pre-modern Europe"[11]. The 15th- and 16th-century explosion of witch imagery was not decoration of the witch hunt but constitutive of it: "images of witchcraft and sorcery printed in pamphlets and other visual sources during the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries transformed and sensationalised the narrative of witchcraft and its dangers"; the creators of the new images functioned as "mediators between the elite world of theology and demonological theory on the one hand, and popular perceptions of unseen dangers in everyday life on the other"[11]. The iconography incorporated "themes not previously prominent in discussions of witchcraft and not necessarily related to one another" — including "male fantasies about female power, superstitions attributed to non-Christian peoples, and ideas about New World cannibalism" — and Zika argues, "very convincingly, that such transformations contributed to a wider acceptance of witch-belief in the sixteenth century and underpinned persecutions during that period"[11]. His larger thesis: the images "helped to fuse demonological theory and theology with contemporary (that is, sixteenth-century) perceptions of medicine, of sexuality and gender, and of peasant belief"[11].

Zika is, in a very direct sense, the missing partner to Federici for the primary period. Federici argues that the witch hunt was constitutive of primitive accumulation[12, 13]; Zika argues that the witch *image* was constitutive of the

witch hunt[11]. Put the two together and one has a materialist iconography of the witch — the female sign of demonic threat as a piece of ideological infrastructure that the hunt required in order to run. Federici cites parts of Zika's milieu but does not fully take on the visual-culture argument. The present essay's move — the extension of that materialist iconography from the *witch* (Zika's object) to the *civic Maiden* (Warner's object) — is a logical continuation of what Zika did for the primary period. If the witch hunt had to travel on images to be thinkable, so, perhaps, did the state that later put the disciplined female form on its money.

A taxonomy. The predecessors above fall into three groups, and it is worth naming them precisely so the essay's own contribution can be located.

- *Materialist iconography without Federici's reproductive-labour thesis.* Doy is the paradigm case. She has class analysis, revolution, and the female sign as class artefact; she does not have the witch hunt as constitutive violence of gender.
- *Federician analysis without civic allegory.* The "witching of art history" current — Deepwell, Naessens, Kokkinen, Turley-Sonne — and Kozomora on ex-Yugoslav contemporary art[3–7]. They read the witch through Federici; they do not read the civic Maiden.
- *Methodological infrastructure.* Mansoor demonstrates the method (iconography whose substrate is primitive accumulation); Vishmidt sharpens the theoretical hygiene around "the body"; Zika supplies the archival-visual-culture argument for the primary period. None of them applies the resulting apparatus to Marianne, Britannia, Justitia, or Columbia.

The essay's proposed contribution sits in the intersection of the three: Federician analysis (with the reproductive-labour thesis intact), of Warner's canonical objects (civic female allegory on the coin and the pediment), using Mansoor's methodological example and Zika's kind of visual-culture argument as the model.

IX. Where the bridge is still missing

The catalogue above establishes that the traffic between Warner and Federici is real and has produced a decade or more of interesting work. It also establishes what has not been done. This section names the specific gap that Sections IV–VII were attempting to fill.

A sustained materialist iconography of female civic allegory proper. The Warnerian object is a very specific thing: the abstract civic Maiden — Marianne, Britannia, Justitia, Columbia, Lady Liberty — on the coin, the seal, the courthouse pediment, the national frontispiece. It is *not* the witch (Zika, the "witching" current), *not* the maternal-biographical figure (Kozomora on the ex-Yugoslav nation-body is closest, but her objects are contemporary artists, not the historical civic allegories), *not* the class-marked female figure of revolutionary or Communard imagery (Doy is closest, but she does not have Federici's mechanism). The cleanly Warnerian civic allegory has not, so far as this essay's search could determine, received a sustained Federician treatment.

Doy comes closest for revolutionary France — her chapter on "women and the bourgeois revolution of 1789" is, effectively, the class analysis of the political-female moment in which Marianne consolidates[2]. But Doy is pre-*Caliban*; the specific Federician mechanism (witch hunt as constitutive violence, reproductive labour as capitalism's hidden abode) is not in her toolkit. A reading of Marianne that combined Doy's class-of-1789 with Federici's reproductive-labour thesis would produce something like Section IV; nobody had done it.

Kozomora comes closest for the nation-body — her formulation of women as "metaphoric markers of the national body, a symbolic battlefield" during the ex-Yugoslav transition is the argument this essay is trying to run on Britannia and Columbia, on a different accumulation and a different century[3]. But her objects are contemporary artists working through the ex-Yugoslav witch, not the eighteenth- and nineteenth-century civic allegories through which

the modern nation-state consolidated.

The "witching" literature comes closest for the mechanism — the reclamation of the witch as an anti-capitalist emblem, worked through contemporary artistic practice[5–7]. But it is committed to the witch as its object. The civic Maiden — the icon whose function is precisely to be *not* the witch, to be the cleaned-up state form the witch was killed to produce — is outside its frame.

The structural argument has no developed application. The Goux/Cady general-equivalents argument that Section III made central is, on the essay's search, the closest theoretical scaffolding for a materialist iconography of civic female allegory[14]. It has not, so far as could be determined, been pulled through to developed readings of specific icons. Cady applies it to money and the female body in early modern literature; Goux applies it to general semiotics. Neither takes the next step to Marianne on the franc, Britannia on the pound, Justitia on the courthouse pediment, or Columbia on the American medal. The essay's sections IV–VII are attempts to do exactly that.

Zika's argument has not been extended forward in time. Zika's demonstration that the witch hunt travelled on images — that the visual culture of demonology was constitutive of the persecution, not decorative of it — is the model for a materialist iconography of the primary period[11]. The obvious next question, and the one this essay is asking, is whether the state that consolidated *after* the witch hunt travelled on images in the same way — whether the disciplined female form on the coin and the pediment is doing analogous ideological work at analogous scale for the mature capitalist state. Zika has not asked the question; nobody working in his tradition has, either.

The Warner–Federici comparison has not been staged head-on. This is the smallest but most striking gap. The two authors are frequently cited together — Warner as the iconographic reference for the female civic sign, Federici as the political-economic reference for the female body under capital — but the essay's search located no paper that stages the comparison in its own right. Section II attempted the comparison. The predecessors closest to that operation (Kozomora, Doy) do half of it: Kozomora holds both frames at once but on a contemporary object; Doy operates on the historical object but does not have Federici's mechanism. Nobody, so far as could be found, has run the comparison directly.

A note on completeness. Two disclaimers close this section. First, the search that produced these predecessors was a paper-and-web search, not an archival search of monographs and edited volumes, where synthetic work of the kind proposed here is more likely to live — Kokoli's *The Feminist Uncanny*, work coming out of *Third Text*, exhibition catalogues from shows like *Witch Hunt* or *Magic Women*. The gap this essay is describing may be smaller in book-length scholarship than in the journal record. Second, the absence of a paper that stages an argument is not proof that the argument is right. It is only evidence that the argument has not been staged. The essay's proposed contribution is a synthesis of two adjacent literatures rather than a review of an existing one — which is both its opportunity and its exposure. Section XI returns to that exposure in the caveats.

Section X pulls the four case studies back together as a single template — Marianne / enclosure, Britannia / empire, Justitia / the state form, Columbia / settler colonialism — and states the payoff the essay has been building toward: the female civic allegory as the post-mortem mask of the witch, engraved on the instrument of the general equivalent, resolving in capital's favour the conflict Warner and Federici together let us see.

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